THE NYĀYA-VAIŚEṢIKA

The two systems of the *Nyāya* and the *Vaiśeṣika* are generally summarized together. Their basic books are the *Vaiśeṣika Sūtras* of Kaṇāda with the glossary by Prasasta Pāda and the *Nyāya Sūtras* of Gautama with the commentary of Vātsyāyna. Gangesa in A.D. 1200 gave the system its prevailing logical character.

This system is both realistic and pluralistic. It acknowledges the external world as independently real and no other substances *(Dravyas)*—earth, water, air, fire, *akāṣa,* space, time, self, and *manas* —as ultimately real. Separate reality of universals *(Sāmānya)* of qualities (such as odor, sound, knowledge, *dharma, adharma, karma), Abhāva* (non-existence), and *Samavāya* (a relation of one-sided dependence) are also fully recognized. The physical universe is conceived as consisting of numberless atoms (inferred from the divisibility of objects) and the three all-pervading entities, *akāsa,* space, and time. Every atom is regarded as unique *(Visesa). Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika* believes in the causal theory of origination *(Ārmabhavāda),* that is, atomic aggregation can produce something new and distinct. It does not believe in the preexistence of the effect in the cause *(Asatkāryavāda)* as in the *Sānkhya-Yoga* system.

God is conceived only as an efficient cause or the Being who manipulated the external atoms into creation. Individual selves vary in their past deeds, or *Karma.* The world serves the dual role of enabling the individual to reap the fruits of his *Karma* and also of freeing him from its shackles. The vast variety of the world is made to argue for God's infinite power and wisdom.

Reality of both Self and God is postulated on the basis of introspection and inference. The *Ātman,* or the individual Self, is an eternal spiritual principle although psychically featureless. Knowledge or consciousness appears only when certain external features cooperate with the Self through the medium of the *Manas,* or the mind. The Selves are many and fundamentally distinct.

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Epistemology

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika epistemology is as realistic as its metaphysics. It lays down four *Pramānas* as the valid means of knowledge. They are: perception, inference, analogy, and authority. Perception reveals objects directly and inference, indirectly. Knowledge is true if it works in practical life; the pragmatic criterion, however, constitutes only a test and not the essence of truth which lies in correspondence. Even error has an objective basis. A rope exists; it only appears as something different in erroneous perception